

Spiritual Nourishment

This lesson is the fifth in the series entitled “The Beginner’s Bible Study.” Other lessons in this series can be obtained through the Lehigh Valley Baptist Church.

The lessons are designed to be first studied, then the questions in the back answered, and then reviewed with the help of an older Christian.

***“As ye have therefore received Christ Jesus
the Lord, so walk ye in Him.”
Colossians 2:6***

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In II Timothy 3:16, the Bible says, *“All scripture is given by inspiration of God, and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: That the man of God may be perfect, thoroughly furnished unto all good works.”*

In I John 2:13-14, we read of three different classes of Christians. The Bible talks there about little children, young men and fathers. You’ll find even in the society in which we live people are at different stages of growth. When you and I got saved, we were “baby” Christians.

The Bible calls us little children. As a little child, when it was time for you to eat, your mother had to bring you the food. She put it in your mouth, wiped your face, burped you, changed your diapers and all the rest because you were not able to do that. Soon, as you began to learn how to eat a little, you were set in a high chair, food was put in front of you and you tried to put it in your mouth. You had a hard time and probably threw it all over and probably got it in your hair like a normal baby does. Eventually most of you got to the point where you were coordinated enough to make it from the plate to your mouth without spilling it everywhere.

The Word of God recognizes there are divisions, or stages of growth in a Christian’s life. Maybe you have been saved in recent months and you are just baby Christian. You are just beginning to grow. You are already on the milk, or maybe beginning now to eat some strained food, and that is how it ought to be. But if, as a Christian, you don’t get nourishment you will soon find that your spiritual life will ebb away and you won’t have the strength you need to stand against temptations and trials that come in your Christian life. You will not have the strength you need to meet the needs of other people. You must get the proper spiritual nourishment.

This lesson focuses on the area of SPIRITUAL NOURISHMENT, or how we feed ourselves. Look in II Timothy 3:16-17 again. The Bible says, *“All scripture is given by inspiration of God and is profitable for doctrine, for reproof, for correction, for instruction in righteousness: That the man of God may be perfect, thoroughly furnished unto all good works.”* The Bible claims that it is not like any other book in the whole world. The Bible claims to be the very Word of God Himself. So, as we come to this book, we expect that God is going to use it in our lives. There are four ways in which God uses His Word in our lives. We find all four in this passage of Scripture.

First of all, it is for **DOCTRINE**. From time to time you may talk to folks as I have, and they say, “I don’t want doctrinal preaching!” But I don’t know how you can have anything else because ‘doctrine’ simply means ‘teaching.’ That is exactly what a preacher is supposed to do. In fact, there is no way you can do any kind of speaking without some doctrine associated with it. The Bible is where we ought to get our doctrine.

The Bible is not only for doctrine, but it also says it is for **REPROOF**. Now, reproof is for someone who has gotten out of the way. I like to picture doctrine as being teaching while we walk down the road of life. But every once in a while, as Christians, we will stray from the way. We will get out of the path we belong in. The Word of God comes to reprove us.

It is the same as seeing your children do something they should not do. In a moment of anxiousness you want to stop them from doing what they are doing so you reach over and smack them. Immediately you have their attention. The Word of God is like that. From time to time you may come to church and hear the Word of God preached or someone may quote a verse of scripture to you. Or you may be reading in the Word of God, and all of a sudden it is like a glass of cold water thrown in your face and you

say, “I didn’t know I was doing that wrong!” God uses His Word as a reproof.

But it is not only used as reproof. Thank God it goes further than that. The Word of God is also for **CORRECTION**. It is one thing to get off the road God wants you on, and then get awakened by a “glass of cold water thrown on you” or “slapped in the face”—to be convicted that you are going the wrong direction. But it is another thing to be able to correct your path and get back on the right path. The Bible tells us not only how to walk right, but when we get off the path it wakes us up and reproves us. When it reproves us it doesn’t just leave us in that position. If we will diligently study the Bible and follow it, the Bible claims it will put us back on the right path. Our lives can be reclaimed.

Then these verses tell us it is for **INSTRUCTION IN RIGHTEOUSNESS**. It teaches us how to walk in the right path so we can please God with our Christian life. The Word of God becomes our ‘Book of Spiritual Nourishment.’

Look at I Peter 2:2. The Bible tells us there, “*As newborn babes, desire the sincere milk of the word.*” A baby drinks milk. When you and I are first born again, we need the milk of the Word. We don’t need the meat of the Word yet. There are studies you can do that get deep, long and very intensive and can take a great deal of time and mental effort. Every Christian ought to strive to get to that place in their Bible study. But many people have also gotten “shipwrecked” because they have tried to dig in too deep too quickly and they have not been grounded in the fundamental principles of the Word of God. So we start with the basics.

I want to sum up what we are going to teach with an illustration of your hand. You have, in all, four fingers and one thumb on your hand. Like-

wise, there are five ways you ought to be fed in your Christian life. If you have ever tried to pick up a book with one finger, you are not going to get anywhere. You might be able to pick it up with 4 fingers, but you still won't get a good grip. You need to pick it up with all five fingers to have a good, solid hold on it.

The Bible is compared to a sword in Hebrews 4. What is a sword? A sword is a long metal object with finely honed edges for cutting things (specifically the sword bearer's enemies) in pieces. The best way to use a sword is not to use it with two fingers and swing it in the air. It is liable to fall back on your head and cut you instead of them. You grab it with all the fingers and all the might you have, and you swing it with all of your energy. Some of the Bible swords used in Bible days were so large, they had to literally use two hands to be able to hold on to it.

Sad to say, there are many Christians who have approached the Word of God with one finger trying to pick up the Bible and they wonder why they don't have a good grasp on the Word of God. They wonder why their Christian life is anemic and seems to not have any real power to it. They say, "Why is it that now that I have been saved I haven't overcome all the sin in my life? Why is it that I haven't finally reached the plateau where everything is going great?"

Back when you first got saved you probably were excited about the things of the Lord. You didn't care what came, other people could threaten and the devil could threaten and you laughed and said, "I'm going to live for God forever!" Sadly, about a week or two later, things began to happen in your life. Slowly but surely that joy that was first there has eroded away. It slowly ebbed out. You ask, "How do I get that joy back? Is the Christian life really real? Have I missed it somewhere? What's wrong with me?" And the answer is—Unless you have the proper spiritual

nourishment you'll never grow up to be able to handle the trials of life. If you try it with one finger or two fingers, you are bound to fail. But if you'll use all five ways of spiritual nourishment, you will soon find that your Christian life will begin to grow. So let's look at these 5 areas of spiritual nourishment that you need in your life.

THE FIRST FINGER

HEARING THE WORD OF GOD

Let's start off with number one. The first finger is going to represent hearing the Word of God. In Romans 10:17 the scripture says, *"So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the Word of God."* We are told again in Revelation 2:7, 17, *"He that hath an ear, let him hear what the Spirit saith unto the churches; To him that overcometh will I give to eat of the tree of life, which is in the midst of the paradise of God... He that hath an ear, let him hear what the Spirit saith unto the churches; To him that overcometh will I give to eat of the hidden manna, and will give him a white stone, and in the stone a new name written, which no man knoweth saving he that receiveth it."*

God says if a man has an ear to hear, let him hear. There is a spiritual way of listening to God. You need to hear the Word of God preached. And there is a right way and a wrong way to hear God's Word. We make much of preaching the Word of God here because the Bible says very clearly in I Corinthians it is by the foolishness of preaching that God chose to save those who believed. Preaching is paramount in the Christian life. However, it's not the only way you are going to be fed.

There are some people who only get spiritual nourishment from what the preacher gives them over the pulpit on Sunday morning, Sunday night, or Wednesday night. If that is the case in your life, your spiritual life will

dry up and fall apart. You cannot possibly be fed enough by just coming and listening to someone else preach. It will not work for your Christian life. In fact, the more you grow as a Christian, the more it will be important for you to do your own study and your own feeding.

It is just like when a baby is first born, he is dependent upon somebody else to put the food in his mouth. But eventually, as I found with my kids when they get old enough, I don't have to put the food in their mouth. Instead I have to chase them out of the kitchen so they don't eat too much and the grocery bill doesn't go too high!

As we begin to grow as Christians we need to begin to learn to feed ourselves. How do we hear the Word of God? I want to give you some ideas that will help you as you come to listen to the Word of God being preached. The word sermon comes from a Latin word which means "to stick, to stab, or to thrust." Literally, the job of a sermon is to stick you. It's to stab you. It's to thrust you through.

Any one of those three words is not something that is going to excite me a whole lot. If somebody says, "I'm going to stick you," I don't care if it's a nurse with a needle or a fellow standing there with a butcher knife, I'm not excited about either one of them. If some mugger in the street says, "I'm going to stab you," I'll turn around and run if I can outrun him. If somebody says, "I'm going to thrust you through," and he's standing there with a javelin about ready to stick it through me, I'm going to try to move.

Sometimes Christians say, "Preacher, preach it, step on my toes, give it to me, make it hard, make it straight." The truth is, we kind of enjoy it as long as it's hard preaching and it's hitting the other guy but it doesn't get too close to home. When it begins to stick in our own life, and stab in our

own life, and thrust in our own life, it's uncomfortable. But it is meant to be that way. That is exactly what sermons are all about.

The fact is, according to studies, we forget 90% of what we hear within 72 hours. If you listen right, though, I believe God will speak to you. I believe you can begin to learn in your Christian life and to grow in your Christian life. I believe you can learn more than just 10% if you will listen properly.

Pray for the Pastor, others, and yourself.

Number one, before you come to church, you ought to have spent a little time in prayer. You need to pray for your pastor. Don't take it for granted that he is just going to have a message. Why don't you pray all week for him? He will be working all week to prepare his sermon, so pray for your pastor.

Pray, secondly for other people. There are going to be people in the services who need the Word of God. There are some that do not know Christ as their personal Savior. There are other Christians who are on the brink of going off into backsliding away from God. Maybe it will be the last service they will ever sit in. But if you had prayed that God would do His work, God could use the message to be able to thrust them through, and bring them to a place where they are ready to listen to the Word of God and make things right with the Lord again.

Pray also for yourself. "Lord, show me something today. Help me to draw closer to you. Show me the sin in my life. Show me any error that may be there. Help me to be open-minded and open-hearted to the Word of God. Help me not to be always shoving the message off on other people. Help me to take it personally and examine my own life." If you'll come

praying before you come, you'll find the messages and the services will take on a new meaning for you.

Bring your Bible along—and mark it!

This is a Bible-believing, Bible-preaching church. The preacher's words are not the gospel, but the Bible is the gospel. We come and bring our Bibles and follow along. When you first get saved it may be very hard for you to find the books of the Bible. But the more you look and the more you try to follow and the more you find the different books of the Bible, the more you will become acquainted with the Word of God. It will begin to burn into your soul and you will be able to find the things that you need. So, bring a Bible.

And bring a pen so you can mark your Bible. Sometimes a particular verse may stand out in a message. God will specifically speak to your life through that particular verse. Mark it in your Bible. This Book is not holy in the sense that we must carry it around and in reverence bow down to it. You can write on the pages of this Bible. A growing Christian is one that reads the Word of God and finds a passages that means something to them, and mark the places so they can find them again.

Stay alert.

Do you realize that Satan wants to distract you so you can't listen? You may be sitting during a sermon thinking about what to do when you get home to get ready for lunch. Or what you have to do to get ready for bed. Or what to do to get the kids ready for school. Or what you have to do so you can be ready for work tomorrow. You may think about what you have to do tomorrow and next week and what is going on at the job. Some of you have so many things going through your mind.

According to II Corinthians 10 you need to literally bring your thoughts into captivity and allow the Lord to have control of them. Now that takes work. I don't know about you, but when I come to services and sit down, my mind can take off in a million different ways, especially as a pastor of a church. I am responsible for how the service is going and how everything is in place and I have a million things to think about. When I sit down and another preacher begins to preach, I have to block everything else out of my mind so I can concentrate on what that man is saying to me and to my spiritual life. It does take work to do that. So, concentrate and realize that Satan is going to try to cause your mind to wander.

Listen and concentrate.

Sit close to the front. If you sit in the back, there will be distractions. Sometimes mothers have to go out and take care of their babies. Sometimes nursery workers have to come up to get somebody. Those things are going to happen. Folks are coming in this door and out that door. But when you sit up front there isn't anybody around to bother you. I suggest that you sit as close to the front as is possible.

Take notes.

You don't need a fancy notebook to take good notes. Some things you want to include in your notes are who the speaker is, the topic, the scripture and the date. Use the blank lines and take some notes. Here are some practical hints on this. When you take notes, ask yourself as you begin for at least one idea that God will give you through the message that speaks to your life. "Lord, you've got something for me tonight in this message. What is it? Help me to discern what that one thing is—at least one, maybe more than one, but Lord speak to me in this service through the Word of God."

Write down the outline of the message as best you can. One thing I like to do in my preaching is to use an overhead and just use a very short outline so folks can follow along with where I'm going. Write down the verse references that go with it because then you can go home and look those verse references up again and re-think through the message. Write down, also, any special statements that may speak to your life. Maybe a quick, short statement that has been made that pierces your heart and is used of God.

Taking notes is important. If you'll take notes, you will remember much more of what you hear than you will ever remember if you just sit there and listen to what is being said. You will remember only 10% if you are not taking notes. But if you are taking notes, you will remember 50% of the material afterwards. Plus, you have the notes to look at later, and when you look at the notes you will have instant recall. You can begin to put that whole message back together again.

Personalize the message.

Then, sixth of all, personalize the message. Ask yourself some questions. "What does this message mean to me right now? What is it that God is trying to tell me? What is the main lesson that the Lord is trying to give me? What should I do as a result of this message? What does God want me to do?" God never gives us the Word of God so we can increase our knowledge. He gives us the Word of God so we can do something with it. Don't be just hearers of the Word, but be doers also. (James 1:22)

Here is a thought you might use. When you get home after the service, discuss the message with your family around the dinner table. "What did the preacher preach about? What do you think? How did that speak to you? What did God say to you through that? How did the Lord deal in

your life?” And begin to discuss it. You may find that God will begin to use it in your life even more so at the dinner table than He did in the services themselves.

THE SECOND FINGER READING THE WORD OF GOD

The second finger is reading the Word of God. It is not enough just to hear the Word of God, but you need to be reading it for yourself. I Timothy 4:13 says, *“Till I come give attendance to reading, to exhortation, to doctrine.”*

When I first got saved, I didn’t like to read. When I was in high school I hated reading. If you would turn a television on I could sit down and watch it all day, but hand me a book, forget it! But something happened when I got saved. All of a sudden I got interested in what God had to say. I began to read more and more. Now I’ve got a large library, maybe 5,000 books, most of them about the things of God. I read the Bible through several times every year. I love the Word of God. I would rather read the Word of God than anything else I could think of. The Bible is my life.

As Christians, we ought to give attendance to reading and make it a prominent part of our Christian life. Revelation 1:3 tells us, *“Blessed is he that readeth, and they that hear the words of this prophecy, and keep those things which are written therein: for the time is at hand.”*

Some people say the Bible is hard to read through. But listen to these statistics: if I read seven pages daily, I will read the Bible through in approximately two-hundred and twenty-four days—that’s one and one third times in a year. That is only seven pages a day. That is not very much. But listen to this: if I read fourteen pages a day, I will read the

Bible through in one hundred and twelve days—that's three times a year. That is only fourteen pages a day. If I read three chapters a day, and I continue, basically, that same reading schedule, in one year I will have read my Bible through one time. We need to be reading the Word of God.

THE THIRD FINGER

STUDYING THE WORD OF GOD

Acts 17:11 says, *“These were more noble than those in Thessalonica, in that they received the Word with all readiness of mind, and searched the scriptures daily, whether those things were so.”*

We need to study the Word of God. II Timothy 2:15 tells us to *“Study to shew thyself approved unto God.”* We need to do more than just hear the Word of God and more than just read the Word of God. It can't just be a newspaper to us. We need to think about what we are doing. We could spend a lot of time here, but there are three things that I want to give you.

Number one, you need a DEFINITE TIME if you are going to study the Word of God. You need a definite time for some personal devotions to spend some time alone with the Lord. Number two, you need a DEFINITE PLACE to spend time with the Lord. I would suggest you find a corner or an office or a closet or someplace, a room where you can study away from distractions. Third of all, you need some DEFINITE CONTENT to that study.

The first kind of study you need to do and put into your life is a daily Bible time or daily personal devotions. It doesn't have to be a long time. It can be 10 or 15 minutes to start out. The secret is you don't want to spend a lot of time and get bored and worn out so that you don't enjoy it. You want to keep it short, concise and you want to spend enough time so

you are thinking through the Word of God and asking yourself some questions. The key to personal devotions is not quantity, it's quality.

Ask yourself some questions. What, in these verses, helps me to **PRAISE** God? What does it say about my God? How can I glorify God through what these verses say? Maybe it talks about His strength, His majesty, His wisdom, or some other attribute. Write down where the verse is found, then spend some time talking to the Lord about that.

Then secondly, ask about **PRAYERS**. Where in these verses are some prayer promises? How did others pray? What are some things I could pray for in my life and in other people's lives? Then spend some time in intercession for other people and needs of folks that you know of.

Then ask the question about **PROMISES** that are in the Word of God. Maybe there are some promises about what God will supply in our church's life or in your life individually.

Then ask: What are the **PRECEPTS**, what are the teachings that are found here, the doctrines that are laid down? Look through those and think through some of those ideas.

The next area is **PRINCIPLES**. Ask: What are some principles, some rules that I can set down for how I will live my life. I will always do this, or I will never do this. I will let my life be guided by this particular insight of scripture.

Then go to **PRACTICE**. This one is the most important. What am I going to do now that I have read this passage of scripture? Notice you are not asking what you are going to do next year or next week, but what you are going to do now. Application of God's Word is important.

For example, when you determine, “I’m going to do something about this!” then you are looking for the opportunity. Maybe the Lord speaks to you about soulwinning. So you are praying all day long, “Lord, You told me that you want me to witness to somebody. Now bring them across my path. Who is it going to be, Lord?” Then when God answers your prayer, what excitement there will be in your heart!

The last section here is **PERPLEXITIES**. There may be questions you have. You are not going to understand everything in the Bible, nor are you going to have time to do a lot of deep research at this point. That is not the purpose of personal devotions. But jot down those ideas, and you can later study them or ask somebody and get some ideas to help you.

THE FOURTH FINGER MEMORIZING THE WORD OF GOD

Psalms 119:11 says, “*Thy word have I hid in mine heart that I might not sin against thee.*” The Bible talks about hiding the Word of God in our heart. Deuteronomy 6 talks about how we ought to have the Word of God in our mouth, speaking about it wherever we go.

In Proverbs 7:1-3 the Bible says, “*My son, keep my words, and lay up my commandments with thee. Keep my commandments and live; and my law as the apple of thine eye. Bind them upon thy fingers, write them upon the table of thine heart.*” Now, how do you write the Word of God on your heart? Obviously you can’t get a surgeon to cut your heart out and then etch it all on there, stuff it back in and tie it up for you. That is not going to work. You hide it on your heart by memorizing the Word of God.

I memorized Psalm 91:1 this week. “*He that dwelleth in the secret place of the most High shall abide under the shadow of the Almighty.*” Boy,

you talk about a powerful verse. That verse is just packed with all kinds of nuggets of truth. The Word of God needs to be memorized. We need to hide it in our hearts so that we are able to then use it as spiritual ammunition to ward off temptation, to deal with temptation, to deal with other people, encouragement in other people's lives.

THE FIFTH FINGER

MEDITATING ON THE WORD OF GOD

We have gone over the first four fingers of our spiritual hand. Now to get a good grasp on the sword of God's Word, we need to add the fifth finger which is meditating on the Word of God. In I Timothy 4:15, *"Meditate upon these things; give thyself wholly to them; that thy profiting may appear to all."* Psalm 1:2 says, *"But his delight is in the law of the Lord; and in his law doth he meditate day and night."*

In Joshua 1:8 we find the secret of success. Have you ever wanted to be successful? Success isn't in some sales meeting where they tell you if you do "these ten things and you will make a million dollars." Success is in Joshua 1:8. It says there, *"This book of the law shall not depart out of thy mouth; but thou shalt meditate therein day and night, that thou mayest observe to do according to all that is written therein: for then thou shalt make thy way prosperous, and then thou shalt have good success."*

How do you make good use of verses that you have memorized? You meditate on them in your own personal life and then from that personal meditation, you find opportunities during the week to share the thoughts that God has given you and the verse that God has given you with other people. Pick a verse every week to memorize and begin to meditate on that verse. Some of you may say, "How do I go to sleep at night? It seems like it is so hard to go to sleep." Some people are taking all kinds of pills

to go to sleep at night. I'll guarantee you, if you begin to memorize the Word of God, and meditate on the Word of God, you will go to sleep peacefully at night.

We found this with our children, when they had nightmares when they were younger, we started to teach them to memorize the Word of God and meditate on the Word of God and as they began to do that, their nightmares were not there. They often disappeared. God used the Word of God in their lives in that manner. If you will use it in your life, it will help you a great deal and it will help throughout your whole Christian life.

CONCLUSION

We need five things to grasp the Word of God properly: Number one, we hear the Word of God. Number two, we read the Word of God. Number three, we study the Word of God. Number four, we memorize the Word of God. Number five, we meditate on the Word of God. And without them you will not have proper spiritual nourishment. These are five things that are necessary for spiritual growth.

QUESTIONS ON SPIRITUAL NOURISHMENT

1. List four ways from II Timothy 3:16 in which the Bible profits us.
2. Is it wise for a “baby” Christian to eat meat as soon as they are saved?
3. “So then _____ cometh by _____, and hearing by the _____ of _____. (Romans 10:17)
4. List several ways by which you can be a better “hearer of the Word.”
5. What was Timothy to give attendance to in I Timothy 4:13?
6. What is a person called if he reads the Bible according to Revelation 1:3?
7. We need to study the Bible to show ourselves approved to whom?
 - a. spouse
 - b. neighbor
 - c. employer
 - d. God
8. List seven “P’s” to help you in daily Bible study:
P _____ P _____ P _____ P _____
P _____ P _____ P _____

9. Write out one verse you will commit to memory this week:

10. From Joshua 1:8, what is the best formula for success:

_____ + Observance = SUCCESS